

POU11011 — Short assignment: the blog post

30% of the module mark · Michaelmas Term 2026

Dr Noah Buckley

New document — Claude’s proposal. The 800-word blog post and its weight come from the filed module outline. The genre spec, suggested structure, draft prompts and failure-mode list are Claude’s, adapted from last year’s Intro (Parente, MT2025) and public political-science blogs. First-years have almost certainly never written for this genre, which is the argument for spelling it out — but the length is yours to cut.

The short version

Weight	30% of the module mark
Length	800 words, 10% either way (references, links, image captions excluded [TBD: confirm — carried over from MT2025, never confirmed by Noah])
Format	A blog post, not an academic essay
Prompts released	Released in lecture and on Blackboard, in due course
Due	Friday 23 October 2026, 23:59
Submission	Word or PDF via Blackboard (Turnitin), Submission Form as page 1
Sources	At least two module readings

What you are actually being asked to do

Take one concept from the module and use it to make sense of one real political situation.

Depth beats breadth every time. One concept, one case, 800 words. A post that gestures at power *and* the state *and* legitimacy will lose to one that takes the second face of power seriously for three paragraphs.

What a blog post is

A blog post **integrates your own perspective with evidence and analysis** — less formal than an essay, freer with structure:

- **A hook** — open on the case, not “In this blog post, I will argue...”.
- **Short paragraphs, headings, bold text**, where they earn their place.
- **Links and images welcome**; they **don’t count toward the word limit**.
- **First person is fine**.
- **Referencing still required** — informal register, formal citation, at least two module readings; the reference list doesn’t count either.

Not an opinion piece with citations bolted on, and not an essay with headings bolted on — if deleting every heading loses nothing, you’ve written the second one.

Good models: [LSE blogs](#), [The Conversation](#), [Good Authority](#).

A structure that works

Not a template — but this shape works at 800 words.

1. **The hook (~100 words)**. The case, concretely — what happened, and what’s odd about it.
2. **The claim (~50 words)**. One sentence saying what you’re arguing, stated early.
3. **The concept (~150 words)**. Name it, define it properly, cite where it comes from.
4. **The work (~400 words)**. Apply it — two or three moves, each with a specific detail from the case. This is where the mark is won.
5. **The limit (~100 words)**. What your concept does *not* explain about this case. Cheapest way to move up a band.

The prompts

Prompt options are released in lecture and on Blackboard, in due course, tied to what's actually happening in October 2026. The drafts below are the standing concept-anchored forms — the released versions will name specific cases.

[DECISION for Noah — the final prompt list is yours. Below are drafts anchored to the portable concepts from lectures 1–10. Pin each to a live case ~3 weeks before the deadline; last year's prompts named the case in the question itself, which worked.]

Prompt A — Power

Pick a recent political decision or non-decision. Using the **three faces of power**, work out where the power actually lay. Which face best explains what happened — and how would somebody disagree with you?

Prompt B — The state

Choose a state in the news. Using **state capacity** — and distinguishing coercive, extractive and administrative capacity — explain one thing that state is failing, or managing, to do. What does the case show about why capacity is not one number?

Prompt C — Ideology

Take a live political controversy. Show what a **liberal**, a **conservative** and a **socialist** answer to it would actually be — not the caricatures, the serious versions — and say which one the policy on the table most resembles.

Prompt D — Regimes and measurement

Take a country that is genuinely hard to classify as democratic or authoritarian. Using one concept from the regimes lectures (**polyarchy**, **competitive authoritarianism**, or a specific index), argue for where it sits — and say what is at stake in the label.

How it is marked

Marked on **argument** · **use of concepts** · **evidence** · **structure and writing** · **referencing**. For this piece, **use of concepts** and **evidence** separate the top of the pile from the middle.

Common failure modes

These are the ones that actually turn up, in rough order of frequency.

- **Describing the concept instead of using it.**
- **Too many concepts.**
- **No case, or a case the size of a continent** — e.g. “Democracy in Europe”.
- **The essay in disguise** — formal register, headings bolted onto continuous prose.
- **Decoration, not format** — bold everywhere, a stock photo, four headings for 800 words.
- **Sources that aren’t sources** — a newspaper link is evidence, not an academic source.
- **Over the word limit.** 800 words carries a 10% tolerance either way; outside 720–880 costs up to 5 marks. State your count at the top.

Submission-form category	This assessment
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Generative AI

Permissions for this assessment, in the vocabulary of the Assignment Submission Form:

Submission-form category	This assessment
No GenAI used	Always fine. No penalty and no advantage.
Brainstorming	Permitted. Explore angles, argue with it about your thesis, generate objections to argue against.
Research/learning assistance	Permitted, with a warning. Use it to unpack a concept or a hard passage, then verify against the module readings. Do not ask it for references: it invents them, and a fabricated citation is a fabricated citation regardless of origin.
Writing assistance	Permitted, slightly wider than for the essay. Register is part of what this assignment practises, so you may ask for feedback on tone and blog-style structure, and may have it rework passages you wrote. The argument, the case, and the analysis must be yours from the start. Substantially revise and fact-check anything it hands back.
Direct AI content inclusion	Not permitted in the body of the post. <i>Exception:</i> if the AI output is itself your object of analysis, you may quote it, in quotation marks, cited per the Library guide , and flagged on the form.
Other use	Describe it on the form. If in doubt, ask me <i>before</i> the deadline; asking is never held against you.

Submission

- Word or PDF, via Blackboard (Turnitin).
- **Assignment Submission Form as page 1**, plagiarism declaration and GenAI disclosure completed. Without one, not accepted — treated as not submitted until resubmitted with one. Does not count toward your word limit.
- State your word count at the top.
- Back it up, and submit early enough to survive a technical problem. Keep the receipt.

Late work and extensions: [module outline](#) — same for every component, not repeated here.